PROactive PRONUNCIATION

STRESS

Stress For Emphasis

A reason we might change the stress in a sentence is to emphasize a specific word. Below are examples of sentences that can be stressed in many different ways, each way changing the meaning of the statement:

I never told you she stole that money:	The speaker never mentioned it.
I **never** told you she stole that money:	The information was never told.
I never **told** you she stole that money:	The speaker never explicitly said it.
I never told **you** she stole that money:	The speaker may have told another person.
I never told you **she** stole that money:	The speaker said someone did, not her specifically.
I never told you she **stole** that money:	The speaker didn't say that the money was stolen.
I never told you she stole **that** money:	She may have stolen different money.
I never told you she stole that **money**:	She may have stolen a different item.

De-Stressed Words

These are the words to really rush through quickly, almost deleting the vowel in the word entirely. Beside each word is how the term can be pronounced in its reduced form. Often, to destress a word, we neutralize the vowel to schwa "uh."

a "uh"
an "uhn"
and "uhn"
are "er"
as "uhz"
at "uht"
because "buhkuz"
can "cuhn"
for "fer"
in "n"
of "uhv and uh"
or "er"
our "ahr"
to "tuh" (if followed by a vowel, then it is "too")
you "yuh"
your "yer"
the "thuh"

Pronouns (he, she, me, they, we, I, them, etc.) become reduced or unstressed.

Sentences: (Rush through the underlined destressed words)
Where's the remote?
What's the time?
She can do it
I'm going to leave
She has a lot to say

I'm learning to speak Spanish
I'm going to go to the grocery store
You'll need to get there on time
He's one of a kind
Was that for you?
He's on his way to the store
I have to find a washroom right now
You are kind and sweet
It's as big as a mountain
You have to line up one at a time
Leave your umbrella at home today
I knew it because she told me yesterday
One by one, they came into the office
I can take your next order
It's for you
I can see you
Practice your pronunciation
I was going to pick you up later tonight
As far as I can tell, the show is canceled
There's one for you and one for me
It's one and the same
I found the document on my computer
You can come to **my** place, or I can come to **your** place
He can drive you there
How are you doing today?
He's been feeling pretty down and out lately
Was this piece of cake mine or yours?
You left your phone at **my** place
This is our favorite place to eat

De-Stressed "A"

The word "a" is a special function word. Because it is unstressed, English speakers tend to reduce the pronunciation to a simple "uh" rather than "aa" or "ey" when a consonant follows it. The result is a quicker, more natural reduction of the word. If the word "a" is followed by a vowel, however, the "a" will be pronounced as "an." For example, "a door" is pronounced "uh," because there is a consonant after the word.

In the phrases below, practice reducing the word "a" to "uh," and "an" to "uhn."

He had a plan
I grabbed a piece of paper
We had a deal
I learned a lesson
I held a cup in my hand
She sat in a chair
We're in a good place
That was a good decision
You had a great idea
We did a good job

What a beautiful place
Have a nice day
Have a great evening
What a day
What a great game
There's a letter for you
I had a report due today
A paper got jammed
I need a pen
Do you have a clock here?
I need a washroom break
I need to make a decision
We had a discussion
She won a prize
What an ordeal
He's an organized guy
I love an interesting story
That's a plan

De-Stressed "To"

The word "to" is a special function word. Because it is unstressed, English speakers tend to reduce the pronunciation to a simple "tuh" rather than "too" when a consonant follows it. If the "to" is followed by a vowel; however, the "to" will be pronounced as "too." For example, "going to go" is pronounced "tuh," where "to our place" would be pronounced "too."

according to legend
appeal to the masses
back to back
bound to happen
cater to you
come to terms with it
it comes down to you
cut to the chase
day to day
desire to love
down to earth
drink to that
end to end
eye to eye
face to face
fall to the ground
get to go
go to my place
go to our place
have to understand
he's dressed to the nines
head to toe
hold on to your hat
hot to trot
I'll see to it
in order to get there
it boils down to this
it's up to date
kept up to speed
lead to win
lean into it
learn to speak Mandarin
live up to your standard
look forward to it
look up to you
need to get around
next to me
not to mention
on to the next
people to see
places to explore
put down to paper
read to learn more
refer to the sign
resort to jokes
right to privacy
side to side
so to speak
speak to that point
stand up to him
stick to it
straight to the point
subject to reason
thanks to you
time to time
to and fro

to begin with
to no avail
turn to your partner
up to no good
used to do it
want to understand
way to go
what to do
where to go
will come to pass
willing to forgive
year to date
your right to vote

De-Stressed "The"

English speakers tend to reduce the pronunciation to a simple "thuh" when it is followed by a consonant. If the "the" is followed by a vowel, however, it will be pronounced as "thee." For example, "the cat" is pronounced "thuh", where "the end" would be pronounced "thee."

all the way out
at the end of the day
begs the question
but in the meantime
by the way
don't pass the buck
for the most part
get to the point
going off the grid
gotta face the music
have to bite the bullet
he kicked the bucket
he paved the way
he's all over the place
he's on the run
he's the cock of the walk
he's under the weather
I call the shots
I'm on the fence
I'm on the job
in the face of fear
it's all the time
it's in the air
it's in the making
it's off the hook
it's on the ground
it's the law of the land
just toe the line
let's clear the air
let's just cut to the chase
not on the spot
off the beaten track
on the contrary
on the go
on the other hand
one and the same
out of the way
over the counter meds
seize the day
she let the cat out of the bag
she made the cut
she's dressed to the nines
shooting the breeze
state of the art
that's beyond the pale
that's out of the question
that's over the top
that's so out of the blue
under the hood
we're on the same page
what a pain in the neck
you're on the ball

PROactive PRONUNCIATION

De-Stressed "Our"

The word "our" is a special function word. Because it is generally unstressed, English speakers tend to reduce the pronunciation to a simple "ahr" similar to "are" rather than "ow wer." This reduction in the pronunciation of "our" makes the word quicker and reduces it to one short syllable.

our family
our house
ran to our park
drove to our favourite place
go to our friend's house
dinner at our place
at our apartment
our last trip
our first dog
welcome to our home
eat in our lunchroom
one of our options

they're our friends
he's our boss
she's our sister
you're our last hope
we're having our lunch
you helped our cause
our printer is broken
our garden is looking great
our grass needs cutting
it's our turn
it's our right
our team did great today

STRESS: Content vs. Function Words

In English, we stress or "linger" on the content words that hold meaning.
We de-stress or speed through the function words or the words that carry less meaning.

Content words

Content words are pretty much all the words that are not function words. For example,

- Nouns (e.g., paper, computer, Peter)
- (Most) main verbs (e.g., play, type)
- Adjectives (e.g., pretty, bright)
- Adverbs (e.g., often, quickly)
- Negatives including "nothing," "nowhere," etc.
- Words expressing quantities (e.g., a lot of, a couple, many, etc.)

Function words

Are typically little words that make the sentence grammatically make sense.
Example: the, a, an, it, she, he, of, in, on, about, around, this, there, have, had. These include:

- Prepositions (in, on, before, after)
- Pronouns (he, she, they, we, us, them, I)
- Determiners (the, a, some, an, a few)
- Verbs (have, be)
- Conjunctions (but, while, as, and)
- Auxiliary verbs (am, can, were)

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Practice

Content words are bold and held longer, while the function words are small and sped through:

State *of the* **art**
On *the* **go**
By *the* **way**
One *and the* **same**
Out *of the* **bag**
All *the* **way**
On *the* **fence**
Shoot *the* **breeze**
Over *the* **coun**ter
Clear *the* **air**
Out *of the* **blue**
Sur**vi**val *of the* **fit**test
Under *the* **wea**ther
I **look for**ward *to it*
Get *to the* **point**
I **go there** *from* **time** *to* **time**
I've **come** *to* **terms** *with it*
We **see eye** *to* **eye**
Get *me* **up** *to* **speed**
He's a **pain** *in the* **neck**
I'm **on** *the* **fence**
I'll **keep** *an* **eye** *on it*
He's **on** *a* **roll**
As a **mat**ter *of* **fact**
I'll **give** *it a* **whirl**
Once *in a* **blue moon**
Take *a* **look** *at it*
John met Sarah
Go *to* **work!**
How *are* **you?**
How *did you* **get there?**
The **boss** *is in the* **office**
She **beat** me

PROactive PRONUNCIATION

I'm **eat**ing *my* **break**fast
I **walked** *to the* **beach**
Don't forget *your* **water bottle**
I'm **almost done** *with my* **work** *for the* **day**
I **wish** *I* **had**n't for**gott**en *my* **bag**
I **love go**ing for *a* **walk** *on a* **bright sun**ny **day** *in the* **ci**ty.
I've been **lear**ning **En**glish *for a* **year**.
I have **so much** *to* **do** *this* **week**end**.**
Peter *and* **Sa**rah *will* **spend** *the* **week**end *at the* **co**ttage *with their* **friends.**
I would **not** *have* **ea**ten *if I had* **known Di**nner *was* **al**most **rea**dy**.**

Stress Practice Sentences

Stress is bold and lingered on, the other items are de-stressed and sped through

Speak of the **de**vil
That's the **last straw**
The **best** of **both worlds**
Nice to **meet** you
Where are you **from**?
What do you **do**?
Are you on **Face**book?
Thanks so **much**
I really a**ppre**ciate it
Ex**cuse** me!
What do you **think**?
That sounds great
Never **mind**
I **don't** under**stand**
Thank you
How do you **spell** it?
What do you **mean**?
Where is the **wash**room?

Can I **have** this de**liv**ered?
How can I **help** you**?**
When is our **mee**ting?
When is the **dead**line?
Don't beat a**round** the **bush**
Better **late** than **nev**er
You've **got** to **bite** the **bull**et
Break a **leg**
Let's **call** it a **day**
Cut him some **slack**
Don't let it **get out** of **hand**
Get out of my **office**
You **missed** the **boat**
She's **on** the **ball**
You're **pull**ing my **leg**
That's the **last straw**
Your guess is as **good** as **mine**

New Information Stress

Wh-question: the content word that carries the meaning in the answer will hold the stressed syllable.

Examples:

What's your **name**?	My name is **Sa**rah.
Where are you **from**?	I'm from **Ger**many.
Where do you go to **school**?	I go to **Har**vard.
What do you **do**?	I'm a **tea**cher.